

MAFIA II

2K Czech has returned back to the world of organized crime after a hiatus of nearly eight years. *Mafia II* is set during the WWII era in a fictional city called Empire Bay, which draws its inspiration from multiple American cities. The game's protagonist, Vito Scaletta, is from a poor family of Sicilian immigrants and a decorated WWII veteran. Vito, along with his sister and widow mother, stays in an unsavory part of the city and he quickly finds himself on the wrong side of the law while in pursuit of good times.

An unfortunate tale

Mafia II stands out from all other gangland games in its more realistic and authentic approach to designing the game world and scripting the storyline. Even though Vito eventually fulfills his ambition, the journey to the top is wrought with betrayal, bloodshed and even a few years in the slammer. The game takes off the sheen of glamour that is generally associated with gangsters in popular media and offers a hard look at life in the underworld. The effect this has on the game is two folds—on one hand this makes for a very convincing and immersive world, but at the same time there are no long lasting rewards. Each time you think you can just kickback and count your fortunes; something really drastic happens and you find yourself working for



Vito embroiled with crime

scraps again. As a player, you are constantly on the run from the law and from other members of the crime world. The game's storyline creates an uneasy air of paranoia, where you expect betrayal at every turn.

This is not GTA

Mafia and *GTA* games may have a lot in common, but they differ in some very fundamental ways. While recent releases of *GTA* are sandbox games, *Mafia II* simply uses an open-world system to create a more convincing world. There is no place in this game for a mad rampage across town with cars, tanks and choppers on your tail. *Mafia* is about organized crime, so the law is broken only when there is money to be made and not just because you feel like it.

Mafia II has a very robust cover system which works better than in most other games. There is also a fair bit of close quarter combat in the game, which uses a fluid and responsive system of blows, blocks and counter attacks.

There is a handsome variety of cars and weapons in the game; however, they are all specific to the era. The game also has



Drive through the streets of Empire Bay

Genre: Action adventure, Shooter

Studio: 2K Czech

Publisher: 2K Games

***Platforms:** PC (Windows),

PlayStation 3, Xbox 360

***Reviewed on PC**

minor car customization options and also character customization by way of classy suits and trousers. There is very little else to do in *Mafia II* besides completing the main story. You can stickup stores or sell stolen cars in the scrap yard to earn some cash, but the reward does not match the effort.

Mafia II is highly recommended for those that do not always look for instant and constant gratification from their games. It is one of the more polished and convincing tribute to the era and the affairs of the underworld by a game; making it fit for the fans of that period. Wish the game had more to do after completing the Story Mode; however, it is not such a bad deal at a price-tag of Rupees 499 on PC.